

Chapter 13

THESE hills look romantic in certain lights and at suitable distances, and seen of an evening from the upper veranda of the club they caused Miss Quested to say conversationally to Miss Derek that she should like to have gone, that Dr Aziz at Mr Fielding's had said he would arrange something, and that Indians seem rather forgetful. She was overheard by the servant who offered them vermouths. This servant understood English. And he was not exactly a spy, but he kept his ears open, and Mahmoud Ali did not exactly bribe him, but did encourage him to come and squat with his own servants, and would happen to stroll their way when he was there. As the story travelled, it accreted emotion, and Aziz learnt with horror that the ladies were deeply offended with him, and had expected an invitation daily. He thought his facile remark had been forgotten. Endowed with two memories, a temporary and a permanent, he had hitherto relegated the caves to the former. Now he transferred them once for all, and pushed the matter through. They were to be a stupendous replica of the tea party. He began by securing Fielding and old Godbole, and then commissioned Fielding to approach Mrs Moore and Miss Quested when they were alone – by this device Ronny, their official protector, could be circumvented. Fielding didn't like the job much; he was busy, caves bored him, he foresaw friction and expense, but he would not refuse the first favour his friend had asked from him, and did as required. The ladies accepted. It was a little inconvenient in the present press of their engagements, still, they hoped to manage it after consulting Mr Heaslop. Consulted, Ronny raised no objection, provided Fielding undertook full responsibility for their comfort. He was not enthusiastic about the picnic, but, then, no more were the ladies – no one was enthusiastic, yet it took place.

Aziz was terribly worried. It was not a long expedition – a

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train left Chandrapore just before dawn, another would bring them back for tiffin – but he was only a little official still, and feared to acquit himself dishonourably. He had to ask Major Callendar for half a day's leave, and he refused because of his recent malingering; despair; renewed approach of Major Callendar through Fielding, and contemptuous snarling permission. He had to borrow cutlery from Mahmoud Ali without inviting him. Then there was the question of alcohol; Mr Fielding, and perhaps the ladies, were drinkers, so must he provide whisky-sodas and ports? There was the problem of transport from the wayside station of Marabar to the caves. There was the problem of Professor Godbole and his food, and of Professor Godbole and other people's food – two problems, not one problem. The Professor was not a very strict Hindu – he would take tea, fruit, soda-water, and sweets, whoever cooked them, and vegetables and rice if cooked by a Brahman, but not meat, not cakes lest they contained eggs, and he would not allow anyone else to eat beef: a slice of beef upon a distant plate would wreck his happiness. Other people might eat mutton, they might eat ham. But over ham Aziz' own religion raised its voice: he did not fancy other people eating ham. Trouble after trouble encountered him, because he had challenged the spirit of the Indian earth, which tries to keep men in compartments.

At last the moment arrived.

His friends thought him most unwise to mix himself up with English ladies, and warned him to take every precaution against unpunctuality. Consequently he spent the previous night at the station. The servants were huddled on the platform, enjoined not to stray. He himself walked up and down with old Mohammed Latif, who was to act as major-domo. He felt insecure and also unreal. A car drove up, and he hoped Fielding would get out of it, to lend him solidity. But it contained Mrs Moore, Miss Quested, and their Goanese servant. He rushed to meet them, suddenly happy. 'But you've come, after all. Oh, how very very kind of you!' he cried. 'This is the happiest moment in all my life.'

The ladies were civil. It was not the happiest moment in their lives, still, they looked forward to enjoying themselves as soon as the bother of the early start was over. They had not seen him since the expedition was arranged, and they thanked him adequately.

'You don't require tickets - please stop your servant. There are no tickets on the Marabar branch line; it is its peculiarity. You come to the carriage and rest till Mr Fielding joins us. Did you know you are to travel purdah? Will you like that?'

They replied that they should like it. The train had come in and a crowd of dependents were swarming over the seats of the carriage like monkeys. Aziz had borrowed servants from his friends, as well as bringing his own three, and quarrels over precedence were resulting. The ladies' servant stood apart, with a sneering expression on his face. They had hired him while they were still globe-trotters at Bombay. In a hotel or among smart people he was excellent, but as soon as they consorted with anyone whom he thought second-rate he left them to their disgrace.

The night was still dark, but had acquired the temporary look that indicates its end. Perched on the roof of a shed, the station-master's hens began to dream of kites instead of owls. Lamps were put out, in order to save the trouble of putting them out later; the smell of tobacco and the sound of spitting arose from third-class passengers in dark corners; heads were unshrouded, teeth cleaned on the twigs of a tree. So convinced was a junior official that another sun would rise, that he rang a bell with enthusiasm. This upset the servants. They shrieked that the train was starting, and ran to both ends of it to intercede. Much had still to enter the purdah carriage - a box bound with brass, a melon wearing a fez, a towel containing guavas, a step-ladder, and a gun. The guests played up all right. They had no race-consciousness - Mrs Moore was too old, Miss Quested too new - and they behaved to Aziz as to any young man who had been kind to them in the country. This moved him deeply. He had expected them to arrive with Mr

Fielding, instead of which they trusted themselves to be with him a few moments alone.

'Send back your servant,' he suggested. 'He is unnecessary. Then we shall all be Moslems together.'

'And he is such a horrible servant. Antony, you can go; we don't want you,' said the girl impatiently.

'Master told me to come.'

'Mistress tells you to go.'

'Master says, keep near the ladies all the morning.'

'Well, your ladies won't have you.' She turned to the host.

'Do get rid of him, Dr Aziz!'

'Mohammed Latif!' he called.

The poor relative exchanged fezzes with the melon, and peeped out of the window of the railway carriage, whose confusion he was superintending.

'Here is my cousin, Mr Mohammed Latif. Oh no, don't shake hands. He is an Indian of the old-fashioned sort, he prefers to salaam. There, I told you so. Mohammed Latif, how beautifully you salaam. See, he hasn't understood; he knows no English.'

'You spick lie,' said the old man gently.

'I spick a lie! Oh, jolly good. Isn't he a funny old man? We will have great jokes with him later. He does all sorts of little things. He is not nearly as stupid as you think, and awfully poor. It's lucky ours is a large family.' He flung an arm round the grubby neck. 'But you get inside, make yourselves at home; yes, you lie down.' The celebrated Oriental confusion appeared at last to be at an end. 'Excuse me, now I must meet our other two guests!'

He was getting nervous again, for it was ten minutes to the time. Still, *Fielding was an Englishman, and they never do miss trains*, and Godbole was a Hindu and did not count, and, soothed by this logic, he grew calmer as the hour of departure approached. Mohammed Latif had bribed Antony not to come. They walked up and down the platform, talking usefully. They agreed that they had overdone the servants, and must leave two or three behind at Marabar station. And Aziz

explained that he might be playing one or two practical jokes at the caves – not out of unkindness, but to make the guests laugh. The old man assented with slight sideways motions of the head: he was always willing to be ridiculed, and he bade Aziz not spare him. Elated by his importance, he began an indecent anecdote.

‘Tell me another time, brother, when I have more leisure, for now, as I have already explained, we have to give pleasure to non-Moslems. Three will be Europeans, one a Hindu, which must not be forgotten. Every attention must be paid to Professor Godbole, lest he feel that he is inferior to my other guests.’

‘I will discuss philosophy with him.’

‘That will be kind of you; but the servants are even more important. We must not convey an impression of disorganization. It can be done and I expect you to do it ...’

A shriek from the purdah carriage. The train had started.

‘Merciful God!’ cried Mohammed Latif. He flung himself at the train, and leapt on to the footboard of a carriage. Aziz did likewise. It was an easy feat, for a branch-line train is slow to assume special airs. ‘We’re monkeys, don’t worry,’ he called, hanging on to a bar and laughing. Then he howled, ‘Mr Fielding! Mr Fielding!’

There were Fielding and old Godbole, held up at the level-crossing. Appalling catastrophe! The gates had been closed earlier than usual. They leapt from their tonga, they gesticulated, but what was the good. So near and yet so far! As the train joggled past over the points, there was time for agonized words

‘Bad, bad, you have destroyed me.’

‘Godbole’s pujah did it,’ cried the Englishman.

The Brahman lowered his eyes, ashamed of religion. For it was so: he had miscalculated the length of a prayer.

‘Jump on, I must have you,’ screamed Aziz, beside himself.

‘Right, give a hand.’

‘He’s not to, he’ll kill himself,’ Mrs Moore protested. He jumped, he failed, missed his friend’s hand, and fell back on to

the line. The train rumbled past. He scrambled on to his feet, and bawled after them, 'I'm all right, you're all right, don't worry,' and then they passed beyond range of his voice.

'Mrs Moore, Miss Quested, our expedition is a ruin.' He swung himself along the footboard, almost in tears.

'Get in, get in; you'll kill yourself as well as Mr Fielding. I see no ruin.'

'How is that? Oh, explain to me!' he said piteously, like a child.

'We shall be all Moslems together now, as you promised.'

She was perfect as always, his dear Mrs Moore. All the love for her he had felt at the mosque welled up again, the fresher for forgetfulness. There was nothing he would not do for her. He would die to make her happy.

'Get in, Dr Aziz, you make us giddy,' the other lady called. 'If they're so foolish as to miss the train, that's their loss, not ours.'

'I am to blame. I am the host.'

'Nonsense, go to your carriage. We're going to have a delightful time without them.'

Not perfect like Mrs Moore, but very sincere and kind. Wonderful ladies, both of them, and for one precious morning his guests. He felt important and competent. Fielding was a loss personally, being a friend, increasingly dear, yet if Fielding had come, he himself would have remained in leading-strings. 'Indians are incapable of responsibility,' said the officials, and Hamidullah sometimes said so too. He would show those pessimists that they were wrong. Smiling proudly, he glanced outward at the country, which was still invisible except as a dark movement in the darkness; then upwards at the sky, where the stars of the sprawling Scorpion had begun to pale. Then he dived through a window into a second-class carriage.

'Mohammed Latif, by the way, what is in these caves, brother? Why are we all going to see them?'

Such a question was beyond the poor relative's scope. He could only reply that God and the local villagers knew, and that the latter would gladly act as guides.